

From Particles to Waves

Towards Coupling Dynamic
Snow Modelling and Spectral
Elements to Detect
Avalanche Breakoff in DAS
Data

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Overview

- Created 3 different models and 2 scenarios for crack propagation in snow using SALVUS
- Two pure spectral element (SE) models, one combined with data from material point method (MPM) simulations
- **Goal:** Couple dynamic snow modelling with SE to model crack propagation in snow

Nomenclature & Abbreviations

- **SE, FE, FEM**: Spectral elements, Finite Element (Method), done in SALVUS
- **MPM**: Material Point Method Numerical Modeling
- **PST**: Propagation Saw Test
- **F-k**: Frequency-Wavenumber Plot
- **DAS**: Distributed Acoustic Sensing (Fibre-Optics)
- **STF**: Source-time function (the wavelet fired by SALVUS)

Why model crack propagation in snow? - Relevance

- 22 fatalities by avalanche in Switzerland every year (SLF, 2025)
- Avalanches are danger for human life but also infrastructure (Schweizer et al., 2003)
- Understanding processes associated with avalanches important
- Avalanche release because of loading, leading to crack propagation in a weak layer (Gaume et al., 2017)

Relevance

- Crack propagation at different speeds: sub-Rayleigh (below vs of material) and Supershear (above vs) (Trottet et al., 2022), transition between two regimes possible (Bergfeld et al., 2025)
- Fast crack propagation → critical crack length for release (Gaume et al., 2015) is reached faster
- Distributed Acoustic Sensing (DAS) already used to monitor avalanches in Switzerland (Edme et al., 2023; Paitz et al., 2023) and Norway (Turquet et al., 2024)
- No knowledge if crack propagation associated with breakoff can be seen in DAS data

Research Questions

- What FE framework is required to to simulate DAS measurements of crack propagation in snow, and what are the key assumptions and limitations?
- What physical phenomena are observed in a two-layer model with a simple STF and how do they differ for sub-Rayleigh versus Supershear crack propagation?
- To what extent do the results change if source wavelets from a MPM simulation of a propagation saw test (PST) are injected?
- How could the phenomena observed be used to distinguish crack propagation regimes in real-world DAS data and aid in detecting snow slab avalanche breakoff?

Simple Model I

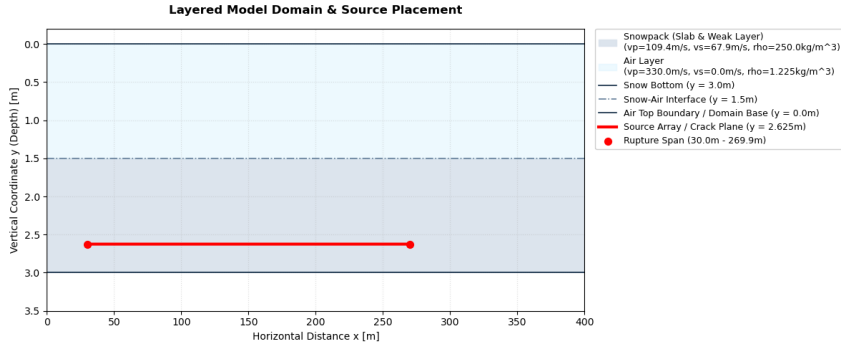


Figure: Two-layer model setup in SALVUS. Colors show materials, material types and properties in legend. Source line extent in red.

Simple Model II

- Set up to test custom STF in SALVUS, see physical effects on output
- Sources spaced over 240m in 10cm intervals
- 20Hz central frequency Ricker wavelet
- Source Wavelet in xx (1), xy (1) and yy (-1) direction
- Time delay of wavelet calculated based on propagation speed: sub-Rayleigh speed is $0.6v_s$, Supershear $1.6v_s$ (Trottet et al., 2022)

MPM-Guided Model I

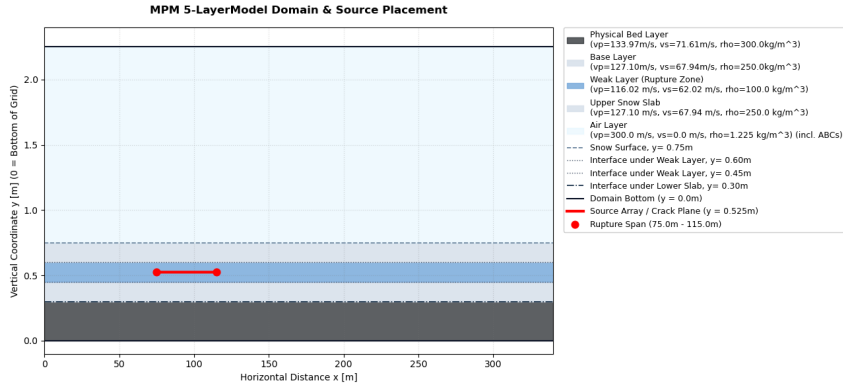


Figure: Five-layer model setup in SALVUS. Colors show materials, material types and properties in legend. Source line extent in red.

MPM-Guided Model II

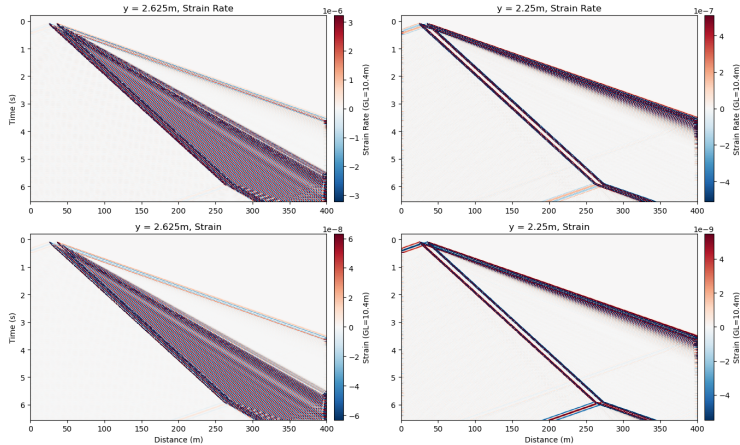
- Source-time functions obtained from MPM-simulation of PST by Trottet et al., 2022
- Source Wavelet in all three directions, but irregular and different for every source point

Results

- SALVUS Output: Displacement field u
- $\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial t} \rightarrow$ velocity in x and y
- $\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial j} \rightarrow$ strain in x and y ϵ
- $\frac{\partial^2 u_i}{\partial t \partial t} \rightarrow$ strain rate $\dot{\epsilon}$
- Simulation of DAS data from ϵ , $\dot{\epsilon}$ using Pyber Gauge length class by **noeFrontiersFullwaveformSeismology2025**, gauge length according to Turquet et al., 2024
- Spate-time plots of strain, strain rate and velocity at different receiver depths
- Frequency-wavenumber plots with theoretical speeds and dispersion curves
- Animations of velocity wavefields

Simple Sub-Rayleigh: Strain and Strain Rate I

Sub-Rayleigh: Simulated DAS Strain Rate and Strain at $y = 2.625\text{m}$ and $y = 2.25\text{m}$



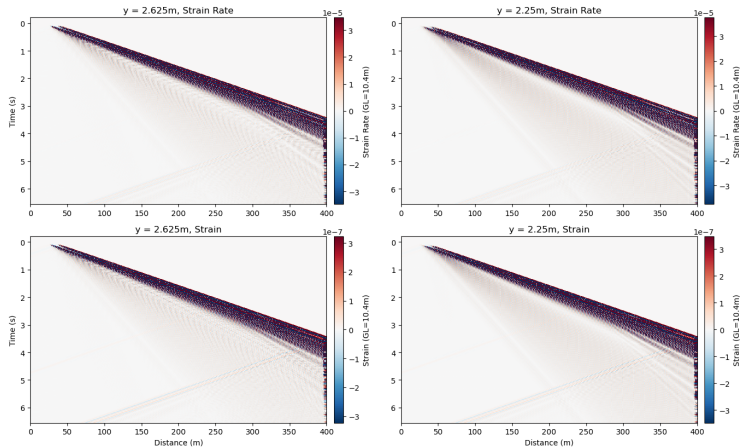
Simple Sub-Rayleigh: Strain and Strain Rate II

Figure: Horizontal Strain and strain rate for sub-Rayleigh crack propagation in simple two-layer model. Plotted at crack depth (2.625m) and at the snow bottom (2.25m). Gauge length is 10.4m.

- Two-wavefront structure
- Main (thicker) wavefront: slope corresponds to prescribed rupture speed
- Second wavefront: coming only from first source
- Wavefront is emitted by all sources but they interfere (**madariagaDynamicsExpandingCircular1976**), as shown by wider source spacing
- Slope of line close to p-wave speed in medium: S0 wave bounded by plate wave speed limit (**roseWavesPlates2014**)
- S0/P-wave precursor observed in field data by **herwijnenSeismicSensorArray2011**
- Oscillatory behavior of both wavefronts (polarity flip at adjacent timesteps)
- At rupture arrest (270m): v-shaped arrest signature: bidirectional, at fastest speed in medium (**freundDynamicFractureMechanics1998**)

Simple Supershear: Strain and Strain Rate I

Supershear: Simulated DAS Strain Rate and Strain at $y = 2.625\text{m}$ and $y = 2.25\text{m}$



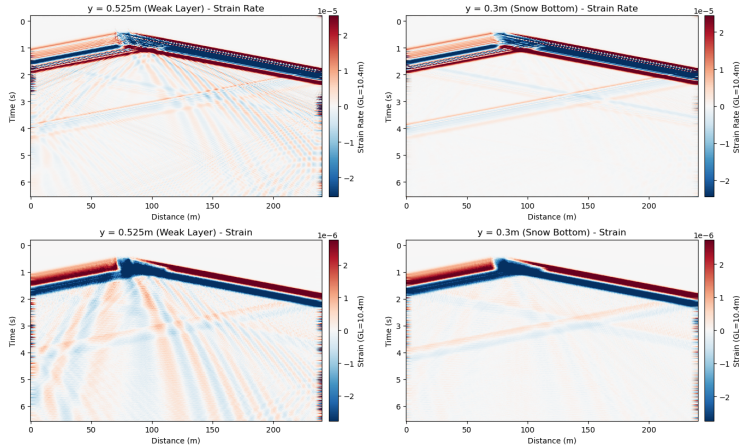
Simple Supershear: Strain and Strain Rate II

Figure: Horizontal Strain and strain rate for Supershear crack propagation in simple two-layer model. Plotted at crack depth (2.625m) and at the snow bottom (2.25m). Gauge length is 10.4m.

- One wavefront, contrary to sub-Rayleigh
- Slope corresponds to rupture speed (within 1m/s of v_p and S_0)
- Dispersion and broadening of main wavefront (**kAkiRichards19801981**)
- Oscillatory wavefront
- At $x=270\text{m}$, unidirectional fan-like arrest front: rupture outruns v_s , so arrest energy is only propagated forward (**madariagaHighfrequencyRadiationCrack1977**)
- S_0 precursor can be seen in traces

MPM-Guided: Strain and Strain Rate I

5-Layer Model: Simulated DAS Strain Rate and Strain at $y = 0.525\text{m}$ and $y = 0.3\text{m}$



MPM-Guided: Strain and Strain Rate II

Figure: Horizontal Strain and strain rate for MPM-guided model. Plotted at crack depth (0.525) and at the snow bottom (0.3m). Gauge length is 10.4m.

- One two main wavefronts observed
- Crack extent from 75m to 125m: sub-Rayleigh speed from front
- Positive wedge in crack area: extends until rupture arrest, then jumps to same thickness as negative front →quasi-static offset
- Backward-propagating front and forward after crack arrest: close to v_p/S_0 from slope
- Second, weaker wavefront: at onset but also arrest: same arrest structure as supershear

Quasi-Static Offset

- MPM STFS

Simple model: Lamb Wave Identification I

MPM-Guided Model: Lamb Wave Identification I

Summary of Results & Discussion I

Implications for DAS field data I

Outlook

Answer to Research Questions - Conclusions

Questions?

Bibliography I



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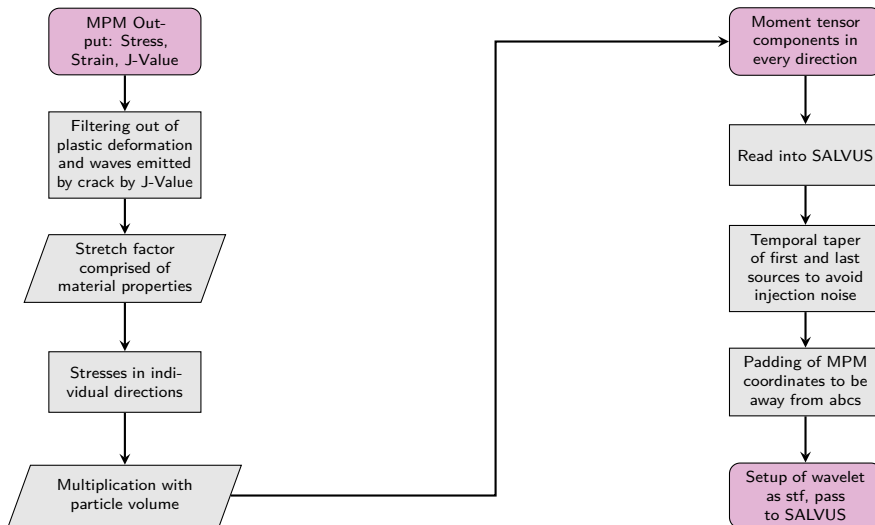


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MPM STF Workflow





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